

Successful proposals should align national and regional research funding programmes on agreed priorities that are common to the countries participating in the action and, where appropriate, implement joint calls for transnational R&I projects as well as other joint calls or other joint activities. Applicants should demonstrate clear commitments from participating programmes to pool resources and ensure complementarity between activities and policies with those of the Framework Programme and relevant European Partnerships and EU missions.

Proposals should pool the necessary resources from the participating national (or regional) research programmes as well as, where appropriate, leverage resources from pertinent foundations, charities and transnational initiatives, with a view to implementing calls for proposals, either within the context of this action or in possible follow-up actions, resulting in grants to third parties without EU co-funding in this area.

The proposals should also demonstrate potential impact at national, regional and transnational level. The proposals should demonstrate that activities exclude overlaps with on-going actions co-funded by the EU under Horizon 2020 or Horizon Europe.

The actions should envisage a duration appropriate to the ambition and complexity of the proposed topic.

IMPROVING ACCESS TO EXCELLENCE

This part of the Work Programme addresses the need to improve access to excellence and to increase the performance of R&I systems, building on dedicated Horizon Europe measures as well as complementarities with smart specialisation strategies under the Cohesion Policy.

Proposals are invited against the following topic(s):

HORIZON-WIDERA-2024-ERA-01-03: Support for the professionalisation of research management

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 1.00 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 1.00 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: This action aims to contribute to improve the European R&I system across the entire ERA by particularly strengthening the capacity for research management in the European Union's public research performing and funding organisations. Actions are expected to:

- Involve a large number of public research performing and research funding organisations and their research management staff in the training and networking programmes, including by improving accessibility for staff from regions of lower R&I intensity;
- Improve training, skills and career development of research management staff in the participating organisations;
- Contribute to professionalisation, including through certification of training programmes;
- Increase recognition of the research management profession in Member States and the important role of research managers across the ERA.

Strengthen research management capacity and support for a Responsible Research and Innovation (RRI) approach across the entire ERA, including in regions of lower R&I intensity.

Scope: Research management takes various shapes across the ERA (and beyond), and therefore its definition/scope is multi-dimensional, including but not limited to the following roles: research policy advice, evidence-based policy making, foresight and strategy development; research coordination, research development, research project and funding management, financial support; evaluation and assessment support; research and complementary training programme management; data-based research support, such as data stewards and data analysts, exploitation of research data, data protection; specialised research infrastructure operation; scientific integrity and ethics expertise, gender perspective support, legal support; science communication support; knowledge transfer and innovation support, knowledge brokering, incubator coordination and business development. In particular, the aim of this action is to further develop and implement a methodology to identify, train and 'professionalise' individuals who are essential support for the 'research enterprise'.

There is a strong need for creating sustained pan-European research management training – both in virtual and in non-virtual curricula. This would help to create solid networks of early career and experienced managers that will last throughout their careers, in the various dimensions of research management for which such opportunities do not yet exist. Secondly, research performing and funding entities, local ecosystems, and regions that are strong in knowledge creation and circulation usually rely on a strong community of research managers. An important challenge for the European R&I system in this respect is the uneven distribution of research management communities and expertise across the ERA. Lower R&I intense countries, regions, institutions often lack such communities, or do not have sufficient access to expertise. Thirdly, the need for new skills is constantly evolving, and upskilling of staff requires ready access to training and practice exchange platforms and across the ERA. Fourthly, there seems to be a lack of recognition of research management as a profession, compared to other policy sectors. Similarly, accreditation of training and career development programmes for research managers in the diverse specialisations is lacking.